and Subramanyar are the best specimens in these temples. Pandyas specially patronised the historic Meenakshi temple at Madurai and kept expanding its premises by adding gopuras and mandapas.



Meenakshi Temple, Madurai

Trade

Arab settlements on the west coast of southern India, from 7th century, had led to the expansion of their trade connection to the east coast because the governments of the east coast pursued a more liberal and enlightened policy towards overseas traders. Their charters exempted traders from various types of port dues and tolls. In Kayal, there was an agency established by an Arab chieftain by name Malik-ul-Islam Jamal-ud-din. This agency facilitated availability of horses to Pandya kings.

In 13th and 14th centuries, horse trade became brisk. Marco Polo and Wassaff state that the kings invested in horses as there was a need of horse for ceremonial purposes as well as for fighting wars. Those who were trading in horses were called *kudirai chetties*. They were active in maritime trade also. The busiest port town under the Pandyas was *Kayal Pattinam* (now in Thoothukudi district) on the east coast. Gold coins were in circulation as the trade was carried through the medium of gold. It was variously called *kasu, kalanchu* and *pon*.

The vast trade in horses of that time has been recorded by Wassaff. He writes: '…as many as 10,000 horses were imported into Kayal and other ports of India of which 1,400 were to be of Jamal-ud-din's own breed. The average cost of each horse was 220 dinars of 'red gold'.

Summary

- The Cholas and Pandyas are well known Tamil monarchs.
- Vijayalaya revived the Chola dynasty.
- The prominent Chola rulers are Rajaraja I and Rajendra I.
- Uttiramerur inscriptions provide details of village administration.
- Kodunkon recovered Pandya territory from Kalabhras. Arikesari Maravavarman and Parantaka Nedunjadayan were his two prominent successors.
- The illustrious rulers of later Pandya kingdom were Sadaayavarman Sundarapandyan and Maravarman Kulasekaran.
- Maritime trade during Pandyas is highlighted by Marco Polo and Wassaff.

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